Week 4: Origin, Growth and Development of Library and Information Science (LIS)

Introduction

The history of Library and Information Science (LIS) reflects humanity's continuous quest to collect, preserve, organise, and disseminate recorded knowledge. LIS as a field of study and practice has evolved from the earliest attempts at keeping records on clay tablets, through the establishment of great ancient libraries, to the modern integration of information science, digital technology, and knowledge management. Understanding the origin, growth, and development of LIS is important for students because it helps them appreciate the profession, its traditions, and its future direction.

Origin of Library and Information Science

(a) Early Beginnings of Libraries

Clay tablets and scrolls: The earliest evidence of recorded knowledge dates back to Mesopotamia (around 3000 BC), where clay tablets were used to record trade, law, and culture.

Ancient libraries: The Library of Ashurbanipal (7th century BC) in Nineveh, Assyria, and the Library of Alexandria (3rd century BC) in Egypt, are examples of early organised repositories of knowledge. These institutions sought to preserve not only local but also international works of literature, science, and philosophy.

Religious collections: Temples, monasteries, and religious centres preserved sacred texts. For instance, Buddhist monasteries in Asia and medieval Christian monasteries in Europe safeguarded handwritten manuscripts.

(b) Early Information Organisation Practices

Ancient librarians acted as custodians of records, but they also developed systems of arrangement. For example, the Library of Alexandria employed methods to classify scrolls by subject and author, foreshadowing modern cataloguing practices.

Growth of Library and Information Science

(a) Medieval to Renaissance Era

During the Middle Ages, libraries were mainly attached to monasteries and universities. Access was restricted to clergy, scholars, and elites.

The invention of the printing press by Johannes Gutenberg (1450s) revolutionised access to knowledge by making books more affordable and widely available. This development stimulated the establishment of more libraries across Europe.

(b) Enlightenment and the Modern Library Movement

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The 17th and 18th centuries saw the growth of public libraries inspired by ideals of democracy, education, and equal access to knowledge.

In the 19th century, library associations such as the American Library Association (ALA, 1876) were formed, promoting professionalism and standardisation in library practice.

(c) Emergence of Library Science as a Discipline

Melvil Dewey (1851–1931): Introduced the Dewey Decimal Classification (DDC) system in 1876, providing a scientific approach to organising books.

S.R. Ranganathan (1892–1972): An Indian mathematician and librarian who developed the Five Laws of Library Science and the Colon Classification system, establishing theoretical foundations for librarianship.

Library schools emerged to train professionals, e.g., the first library school founded by Dewey at Columbia University (1887).

Development into Library and Information Science

(a) The Information Science Revolution

After World War II, the explosion of scientific and technical information gave rise to the field of information science.

Information science focused on indexing, abstracting, retrieval, and the use of computers to manage information.

The emergence of digital technologies, databases, and online information systems transformed traditional librarianship.

(b) Integration of Library Science and Information Science

By the 1960s and 1970s, many library schools began to adopt the term Library and Information Science to reflect the merging of librarianship and modern information science.

LIS became an interdisciplinary field, drawing from computer science, management, sociology, education, and communication studies.

LIS in Nigeria (Brief Preview)

Libraries in Nigeria date back to the colonial period, with early collections established by missionaries and colonial administrators.

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The growth of university libraries, the establishment of the Nigerian Library Association (NLA) in 1962, and the introduction of library schools (e.g., University of Ibadan, 1959) marked key milestones.

Nigerian LIS has grown to embrace digital libraries, institutional repositories, and ICT-based services.

Conclusion

The origin, growth, and development of Library and Information Science demonstrates the profession's enduring role in human civilisation. From ancient clay tablets to modern digital platforms, LIS has evolved to meet the changing needs of societies. Its journey reflects not only the preservation of knowledge but also the advancement of access, organisation, and dissemination of information in diverse forms.

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